14 prompting techniques: cheat sheet

Pick the technique that fits the task, then fill in the template. Not sure which? Paste the Prompt Coach into any chatbot and let it choose.

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#	Technique	Use it when	Template you can copy
SHOW, DO NOT TELL			
1	**Zero-Shot Prompting**	Straightforward, standard tasks where the expected output is clear: summarising, translating, factual Q&A, classification, recommendations.	*[Task]. For [audience]. Answer in [format and length].*
2	**Few-Shot Prompting**	The task has a style, format or logic that is hard to describe in words. Show 2 to 5 examples first.	*Here are examples of what I want: [example 1] [example 2]. Now do the same for: [new input].*
3	**Contrastive Prompting**	Outputs keep drifting the wrong way. Show a good example and a bad one to make the target clear.	*Good example: [...]. Bad example: [...]. Write one like the good example and avoid what makes the bad one bad.*
MAKE IT REASON			
4	**Chain-of-Thought**	Complex problems that need logic, maths or several reasoning steps.	*Think step by step and show your reasoning. Then give the final answer on its own line.*
5	**Step-by-Step Prompting**	Procedures, instructions, workflows and how-to guides where order matters.	*Give numbered steps in order, with what to check after each step.*
6	**Tree of Thought**	Open-ended problems with several valid approaches. Explore branches, evaluate them, then converge.	*Propose 3 different approaches, list the pros and cons of each, then recommend one and say why.*
7	**Self-Consistency**	Accuracy is critical. Run several reasoning paths and compare where they agree.	*Solve this three separate ways, compare the answers, and report where they agree and disagree.*
SHAPE THE ANSWER			
8	**Structural Prompts**	The format of the output matters: tables, JSON, a set document layout. Define the shape before the content.	*Answer as a table with the columns [A], [B] and [C]. Nothing outside the table.*
9	**Persona Prompting**	The perspective or expertise behind the answer matters. Assign a role or identity.	*You are a [role] with [experience]. [Task] for [audience].*
10	**Reverse Prompting**	You want to learn from an example or copy a style: reconstruct the prompt that produced an output.	*Here is an output I like: [...]. Write the prompt that would produce it.*
TALK AND IMPROVE			
11	**AI Interview Technique**	Complex deliverables that need context. Let the model ask questions before it produces anything.	*Before you start, ask me up to 5 questions you need answered. Wait for my answers.*
12	**Thought Provocation**	Challenge assumptions, stress-test an idea, find blind spots. Ask the model to argue against or critique.	*Argue against my plan: [...]. Give the 3 strongest objections and what evidence would settle each.*
13	**Meta-Prompting**	You want to improve or generate prompts themselves. The model writes or refines the prompt.	*Improve this prompt so it gets a better result: [prompt]. Explain what you changed.*
14	**Iterative Refinement**	High-stakes writing. Draft, critique, then revise in sequence.	*Write a draft. Critique it against [criteria]. Then rewrite it to fix the critique.*

Before you send any prompt: say who it is for, what format you want and how long it should be. Do not paste confidential or personal data, and check facts and numbers before you use the answer.